

Masticatory Muscle Myositis (MMM)

What is it?

MMM is a condition in which the immune system mistakenly attacks the **chewing muscles** — the muscles that open and close the jaw. It is most common in **large breeds**, especially **German Shepherds**, usually in young adults (as young as 3 months). Cats are rarely affected.

Signs

- Swollen, painful jaw muscles
- **Trouble opening the mouth**; reluctance to eat or play with toys
- Pain when the face or jaw is touched
- Bulging eyes in some dogs
- Fever
- Some dogs show **muscle wasting** of the head instead of swelling

Diagnosis

- **2M antibody blood test** — specific for MMM
- **Muscle biopsy** to confirm the disease
- Occasionally CT or MRI to rule out other problems

Treatment

- **Prednisone** to control the immune system, usually for 1–2 months at first, then slowly reduced
- About **90%** of dogs respond and return to normal function in **2–3 months**

- About **25%** relapse; some dogs need a second or third immune-suppressing drug
- Some dogs keep lasting muscle weakness or wasting

Do not stop prednisone suddenly — always follow the tapering schedule.

Special nursing care

Until your dog can open the mouth well:

- No exercise or excitement in hot, humid weather, and **no swimming** (panting and cooling are limited)
- Avoid sticks and stick-shaped chews
- Offer soft food that is easy to swallow

Once strength improves — jaw physical therapy:

- Supervised chewing on durable chews (e.g., Nylabone Dura Chew, Benebone Wishbone) for **15–30 minutes, 1–2 times a day**
- **Mouth-opening stretches:** say "Open," gently open the mouth once, then give a treat. Work up to about **5 minutes, 3 times a day**
- Stop if your dog seems painful or sore during or after stretching

Call us if

Your dog cannot eat or drink, jaw pain returns, or signs worsen as the steroid dose is lowered.